

ONGOING HUMANITARIAN INFORMATION, ACTIVITIES AND ISSUES

(Update August 2001)

1. **ETHIOPIA (HOA) – Common Humanitarian Information Network (CHIN) for the Horn of Africa.** The IT / IM Team has developed a regional humanitarian contact database, humanitarian resource tracking data base (who is doing what and where and with what resources) and a Meta data dictionary data base (who has what information and where to go and get it). Support in terms of data base assistance and the provision of products have been provided to Eritrea and Sierra Leone. The 3W data bases from the HOA and other similar data bases are being consolidated to develop a generic standard to be available by the end the summer. The regional data base is now under independent testing pending its release.

The decision to terminate the activities of the ORHC and the transfer of all IM/IT activities to the OCHA regional office in Nairobi or the DEPHA project below is now under discussion. A paper on the possible structure of the regional OCHA office in Nairobi is under preparation

2. **ERITREA: - The Information Co-ordination Centre (ICC)** was established in May 2000. The ICC will continue in its current format until December 2001 at which time it is envisaged that the ICC will transition into ERREC (obviously this will be monitored and planned for during the latter half of 2001). Craig Williams a GIS consultant is also now in place and funding is secured for the GIS unit. The GIS Unit has been established in the ICC as part of a wider capacity building process with ERREC. The ICC has completed questionnaire for the 3W Database and is proceeding with the Pcode study. Government and agency buy in has been secured.
3. **KENYA: - The Regional Data Exchange Platform project (DEPHA):** The final project document has been approved and the project has initiated in earnest. As endorsed by the steering committee at a meeting held on May 15th 2001, the facility (Data Exchange Platform for the Horn of Africa) will be under the UNEP legal frame and implemented by UNOPS.

Voluntary participation and joint ownership are the central pillars of the facility's philosophy. A management steering committee, comprised of UN, donors, NGOs and government representatives is already in place, and is responsible for overall strategic guidance. Responsibilities for administrative support, day-to-day management, and physical hosting will be undertaken by different agencies, currently UNEP and UNOPS. In time, functions and responsibilities will be devolved to the relevant national and regional authorities, including IGAD, and the facility will move from operational roles to backstopping and capacity building.

The Data Exchange Platform for the Horn of Africa (DEPHA), the new incarnation of the fast evolving Humanitarian Assistance Information Centre (HAIC), has finally opened its web site. The site is maintained on a voluntary basis by the DEPHA Secretariat and relies on voluntary contributions from all who believe in this initiative. Sorry if it proceeds slowly, but until DEPHA becomes a physical entity time is a major constraint.

www.hornofafricadata.org

4. **SIERRA LEONE: - The Sierra Leone Information System (SLIS):** The activity and interest in it has grown tremendously in the last two months of its operation. The first "who is doing what where" products have been released. Basic planning maps for collecting field data are being tested in a pilot project. Standardization of data collection is underway on several fronts. UNHCR hired a database person to liaise with SLIS. OCHA assigned one of their staff as a full time GIS trainee. Progress reports are available upon request.

A data coordinator to support the OCHA office in Conakry in terms of data and information will be arriving in Guinea in the next month. The TOR of the data coordinator includes close links with the SLIC in Sierra Leone for regional issues such as data base development for IDP and Refugees.

5. **SOUTHERN AFRICA: Discussions under way with USAID and SADC:** As a result of IMSB/FIS involvement in the Mozambican floods contact with the USAID in DC as well as the water sector secretariat in Lesotho have been maintained in relation to the possible setting up of an Information Management capacity to

support the Gaborone based regional preparedness center where OCHA (DRB) intends to place a disaster response regional advisor (RDRA). The USAID/FEWS project has been working closely with the team to implement a generalized flood model for the various at risk areas in the region. Clear links with the RDRA need to be developed so that the capacities complement and reinforce each other.

6. **KOBE:** In order to strengthen Information Management Capacity within the ADRC the setting up of an IM/IT capacity within the ADRC has been added to the Kobe proposal. The capacity would concentrate on promoting basic standards for the exchange of spatial data; the provision of GIS / Remote Sensing technical / specialists support; Facilitating sharing with partners GI baseline products developed by the existing network; provision of surge capacity and technical support functions in times of crisis in the areas of information management/technologies – as well as GIS and Remote Sensing; and facilitating the development of regional disaster response Information Management Systems. Links with other similar capacities in the region such as the Pacific Disaster Center (PDC) and the Center of Excellence (COE) in Hawaii will be reinforced.

OCHA has recently opened the Relief Web antenna office in Kobe and will be sending a participant to the upcoming International Symposium on Internet based Disaster Information hosted by the Asian Disaster Center in Kobe, Japan.

7. **SOUTH AMERICA – Ecuador: Discussions with UNDP and other members of the UNCT:** Have been held on the setting up of a regional IM / IT – GIS - capacity in Ecuador to cover needs for the region. UNHCR and WFP have expressed interest on an interagency proposal. The same was also discussed with the RDRA in Ecuador as the IM activity would complement and reinforce the RDRA preparedness and response activities. A joint mission with UNHCR to look into the issue of the regional center is being planned for October 2001.